is it casual now?

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55425160.

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Not Rated

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
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by MaryaDmitrievnaLikesSundays

Summary

Five times Catra thinks Adora doesn’t want her, and one time she knows that she does.

Notes

Love lesbians. Love angst. Brainrot

See the end of the work for more notes

“Cadet Adora.”

Catra’s ears perk up. It’s the first time she’s heard another voice since her mother dropped her in a box and sealed the lid. But this isn’t the voice of her mother; it’s a new voice, slow and smooth and a little bit scary, even if she doesn’t understand why.

Catra hears a little shuffling; the singular hole poked in the lid streams through with a dimmer light than before, like she’s been taken to a room with too few windows.

“Shadow Weaver.” It’s clearly said by a young girl, but she seems to be trying hard to be grown-up. Catra doubts she can even spell whatever name she’s just said.

“Cadet, what do you know about the refugees of the rebellion?”

When the girl—Cadet Adora, Catra can guess—responds, it’s with a practiced confidence, as though she’s reading from a textbook. “They’re people displaced from their homes or families by the evil Princesses and their armies. They are rare; Princesses don’t like to leave survivors.”

”Correct. But have you ever seen one?”

A pause. “No, Shadow Weaver.”

”Come look.”

Slowly, the lid over Catra’s head is removed. Even in the dim light she has to blink until her eyes adjust. Leaning over here are two figures—one dark and shifty, like she’s made of—well, of shadows. She makes Catra want to curl into herself and never come out again. The other one, though, is a girl. She looks about Catra’s age, with blonde hair tied back and blue eyes slight with wonder and a smile slowly spreading to show gapped teeth. It’s enough to cancel out the instinct to hide from Shadow Weaver. If anything, Catra feels her ears perking up, her tail starting to swish from side to side on the cardboard. She wants to lean towards this girl. She wants to get closer.

“What happened to her?” Adora asks, but she doesn’t seem to be too interested in the answer. Her eyes are stuck on Catra; her tail, her claws, the unruly puff of her hair.

Shadow Weaver pauses. “Nothing good,” she says.

Not much bad, either, Catra thinks. Yesterday she was one in a litter of twelve whose mother would rather sit with a bottle than her own children. Now she’s indoors, somewhere warm and not immediately dangerous and with this lovely Adora. Personally, she’d call that an upgrade.

”So what do you think, Adora?” Shadow Weaver asks. “Do you want to keep her?”

Adora's expression dims. For the first time since the lid snapped shut overhead and she was taken to wherever Shadow Weaver found her, Catra feels true fear. Just by looking at Adora she knows this place has food, clothes, and maybe even beds. This place has smiles, at least one or two. But what if Adora says no? Will it all be snatched away, just like that? Can that dazzling smile so easily speak the words to banish Catra right back to where she came from?

The silence stretches. Just when Catra is sure Adora's about to tell Shadow Weaver to box her back up and leave her on the doorstep for some other unlucky bastard to find, she instead turns back to Catra. "Do you *want* to stay?" She asks.

It takes a second for Catra to process. She doesn't think she's ever been asked a question before. But she looks around at this room, this light, and mostly, this girl. Her smile makes her feel… good. Happy? Maybe. And Catra's not sure she's ever felt happy, before.

"Yeah," Catra says, voice scratchy with disuse. "Yeah, I want to stay."

Adora reaches a hand into the box; Catra takes it without question and lets herself be helped out, onto the same cold ground as Adora. She's just a little shorter; she finds she can't quite be mad about it.

Adora's smile widens, bright enough to blot out the sun. "Welcome to the Horde, Cadet…?"

And already, Catra knows; knows that Adora is the favorite, that she herself is just some liquor-sick woman's leftovers, that she's not the kind to be called 'cadet' and never will be. But she stares at Adora's toothy grin, and she can't quite bring herself to care.

"Catra," she says, and when Adora takes her hand to shake it, it's the softest thing she's ever felt. "Cadet Catra."

———

"Catra?"

It's a worried voice. Soft, sincere, caring. And it doesn't belong here.

Here, Catra has no name. She's not a cadet, not even a friend. She's back in the alley where they found her, waiting to be snatched up by some monster or another. She won't go gently; if she has to die, she'll die with blood stuck under her claws.

She swipes at the darkness, at the bodies made from shadows, the only other beings in the universe besides her. Even if she wins —then what? She wanders the darkness forever? No matter which way she slices it, she's totally, entirely, horribly alone.

“Catra!”

The sound hardly hits her ears. A shadow finally makes contact, brushing against her arm; she scratches it as hard as she possibly can. It pulls away with a pained yelp. But the strange thing is, Catra *knows* this yelp. She’s heard it before. But where?

”Catra, stop!”

Catra jolts awake. Adora leans over her, one hand hovering over Catra’s chest, the other held up to her own cheek. Despite the darkness, Catra can see blood escaping between her fingers.

”Adora?” Catra asks, only just conscious enough to be ashamed of the waver in her voice.

”You’re okay, Catra,” Adora says. “It was a nightmare.”

”I was…?”

”It’s alright.” Even in the black night, Catra can see Adora’s gentle smile. “I get them, too.”

And part of Catra is angry. Part of her wants to hiss at Adora and tell her to shut up, because she probably doesn’t. She’s just lying

to make Catra feel better, and even if she *did* get nightmares, they'd probably be about Shadow Weaver saying she came in second place during training, or something. Because Adora is perfect, and Catra is anything but, and it hurts enough in broad daylight; it's so much worse in the dark.

But at the same time, Catra's still shaking all over, eyes still darting towards every shadow in the corner of the room. So when Adora glances sheepishly down and says, "You can sleep in my bed, tonight, if you want," Catra can do nothing but accept.

Adora leads Catra past their snoozing roommates and over to her bunk. When she sinks down to the pallet, the dim hall light catches the side of her face, and Catra gasps.

"What?" Adora asks. Just the movement of speaking the word send another few drops of blood sliding down her cheek from four long, jagged claw marks.

"Did…did *I* do that?"

Adora touches her finger to her face and winces, as if she'd forgotten she was hurt at all. Where Catra expects her to burst into shrieking tears like any girl her age would, she just wipes her finger on her pillowcase and shrugs. "It'll stop soon. I heal fast."

Catra can't imagine how she could *possibly* heal quickly from that, but before she can ask Adora has already settled beneath the sheet and onto her side, only the long stretch of her ponytail

visible. Besides, Catra's guilt has climbed up her throat to choke her, stop her breath in her lungs and keep her apologies caught between her teeth.

She just curls up at the foot of Adora's bed, hating how already her heart slows and her muscles loosen, just from having another body so near. She wants to be strong, really she does; wants to be independent, self-sufficient, everything the Horde says that she should be. But she's still Catra. Part of the litter; just one more abandoned kitten looking for something warm to lean up against. At her core, she's a pack animal.

As she drifts off to sleep, Adora's foot brushing against her now and again, she can't help but notice how she's never felt safer in the Fright Zone. How maybe, she's never felt safer in her life.

(And Adora's right—she *does* heal fast. By morning, there's nothing more than a few white scratches on the smooth skin of her cheek.)

———

"Catra! What the hell?"

Catra doesn't stop; she's already thrown down her sparring staff and vest and is stomping out of the training room.
"Fuck *off,* Adora."

”Catra.” Footsteps jogging behind her. “*Catra!”*

Catra whirls around, hair standing on end. *“What?”*

Adora’s eyes widen, but she quickly schools her face to neutrality. Even with stray hairs flying from her ponytail and her cheeks still flushed from the fight, she looks strong. Confident, standing tall in the fluorescent lights of the deserted locker room. Force-fucking-captain-material. “What’s going *on* with you?” She asks.

Catra scoffs. “With *me?* What’s going on with *you?”*

*”*With—“

”Yes, with you! You held me down for, like, a full minute back there! In front of everyone!”

Adora crosses her arms. ”It was *not* a full minute.”

”It was long enough, Adora. It was humiliating. And you’ve been doing this shit for *weeks.* Are you just trying to embarrass me?”

“Why would I try to embarrass you?”

”Because Shadow Weaver needs a new fucking force captain!” Catra shouts. “And you’d rather show her you’re *worthy* of it than let me up off the fucking ground!”

Adora steps back. Something like hurt shines over the sky blue of her eyes, and for a moment, the anger simmering low in Catra’s gut wants to cool. But she won’t let it. Not now, not just because Adora batted her eyelashes and twirled her hair. Not again.

”Catra,” she says softly.

”Save it,” Catra says. “I’m sure Shadow Weaver’s more interested in your flattery, anyways.” She doesn’t wait for Adora’s response. She’s already out the door.

Her feet take her through the Fright Zone’s winding hallways on memory, like the corridors are the ridges of some massive womb from which she’ll never be birthed. It’s strange to imagine she ever had a life outside of this place, that there’s any life beyond these walls at all. Anything but steel and artillery seems unreasonable, impossible, something Kyle would dream up then get laughed at for the next week over. There’s only one thing that makes this place bearable, and these days it seems even she’s done pacifying Catra, too.

By the time Catra’s made it to her favorite perch on one of the Horde’s many sloping towers, the sun is dipping low on the horizon, casting a deep orange haze over the jagged city below. If she squints, she can almost imagine that the whole place has been set aflame.

She could just run. She's fast, and has roughed it out before. As long as she's smart about it, she could sneak out under the cover of night and be miles into the woods by morning. Fuck the Fright Zone. Fuck Shadow Weaver. Fuck Hordak, and the Cadet Squadron, and Kyle and Lottie and Rogelio and…

Catra sighs, pulling her knees up to her chest, and lets her eyes unfocus until the Fright Zone fades out into a fuzz of gleaming metal. Like it or not, this place is home. This place and all of its people. Roommates. Bedmates. And Catra can pretend all she likes, but she knows that she'll never really leave. Not unless Adora leaves with her.

As if on cue, the sound of heavy footsteps and labored breaths hits Catra's ears. She sighs and assumes a relaxed pose just as Adora's clears the roof out of the corner of her eye.

"Catra," she pants. "Why do you always have to climb to the highest places?"

"So annoying blondes might not make the climb to find me."

Adora doesn't take the bait. She sits beside Catra, catching her breath, dangling her feet over the edge as if she, too, will always land on her feet.

When Adora's breaths have evened out in her chest, Catra answers, "The view."

Adora looks to Catra. "Huh?"

"You asked me why I climbed so high." Catra sweeps an arm out, to where the Fright Zone has become a sea of little lights in the darkening sky. "I like the view."

Adora faces out. Catra can see her eyes taking in every detail, probably already analyzing for traffic routes, building errors, best hideouts in case of a siege. Sometimes, Catra thinks she must be entirely immune to beauty, to things that want her to love them, even when they're right in front of her eyes. "Yeah," she says eventually. "I guess it's nice."

A few moments pass in near-silence, the air weightless save for the buzz of electricity, the idle swish of Catra's tail, breeze rattling through the pipes.

Adora says, "I didn't mean to embarrass you."

Catra doesn't even bother turning her head. Adora, of course, isn't phased. "Really, I didn't. But you're right. I *have* been nervous. We're fourteen, Catra, and we're not going to be cadets for much longer."

Catra scoffs. As if she needs reminding.

”So yes,” Adora continues, “I was trying to show off for Shadow Weaver. But only because I thought that you would, too. I just figured we were all fighting for top spot.”

Catra shifts. “Yeah, well. Not all of us.”

“I guess not.” A pause. Catra still won’t look at Adora, but she can just carrot see her hand inch towards her on the metal. “But I didn’t mean to embarrass you. Honestly, I thought you were playing some kind of long game that I just hadn’t figured out yet.”

Catra finally spares her a glance. Adora’s features are stupidly earnest, and Catra knows her too well to even try and tell herself that she’s lying. “Maybe I have,” she says. “Maybe I was just waiting to lure you to some high place to I could push you off.”

Adora’s brows release some of their furrowed tension. “Well,” she says, leaning back on her hands. “Here’s your chance.”

And it’s crazy, really, that Adora trusts her that much. No one is supposed to trust anyone in the Horde. It’s like Adora said: everyone’s fighting for the top. If it was Lottie up here, unprepared for a playful slap, much less a shove, Catra probably would have pitched her over the edge by now. But it’s Adora, all tentative smile and the lazy curve of her spine, putting her life in Catra’s hands for a joke, and the last of Catra’s anger melts away.

”Don’t worry about it,” she says. “As long as you’re smuggling me gray ration bars, you’re more useful to me alive.”

”I don’t get why you like the gray ones so much.”

”I don’t get why you like the *red* ones.”

”They’re good when they’re hot.”

”They’re never hot.”

”Well. Yeah.”

The sky has grown its darkest. No stars, no moon. At night, it often seems like there really is no world beyond the Fright Zone; like Catra might be here for the rest of her life. On her own, it’s a depressing thought. With Adora by her side…

”It is a nice view.”

Catra looks up; Adora isn’t looking at the sky, but at her, eyes soft, lips slightly parted. It’s the way she looks at a red ration bar, or her thin sleeping pad after a hard day. It’s the way Catra’s

dreamed of being looked at for years. But whenever she wakes up, Adora's already there, looking over her shoulder to a future that Catra is blind to. It's terrifying. In fact, the only thing more terrifying than the way Adora looks in those indifferent mornings, might just be the way she's looking at her now.

"Don't try too hard for Shadow Weaver." Catra hears herself say it before she's decided to speak, and regrets it the moment Adora's expression breaks, then hardens over.

"What?" She asks.

"I just mean—don't do too much, too fast. We don't really know what Hordak is like, and if Shadow Weaver takes you to him and he decides he likes you then he might promote you past force captain. And then you'll leave, and we won't be able to look out for each other any more. No more sparring partners, no more ration bar trading. You'll leave. Don't leave, Adora."

She wants to take back every single word as she's saying them, doubly so as Adora's face begins to crumple, but she can't stop. She can usually sharpen her fear into anger, but something about Adora bars her from it, turns her into nothing more than a feral kitten who bonded with the first living thing to show it kindness.

When Adora smiles softly, Catra wants to punch something. "That won't happen, Catra. Hordak has never even seen me. And if he does, I'm sure he won't think I'm any different from the rest of the Horde. That's why we're the Horde, right?"

Catra deflates. Some stupid part in her wanted different reassurances; wanted to hear that it wouldn't happen because Adora needs her as bad as she needs Adora, because one bed is too big without both of them in it, because they're the only things that make life worth living in this shithole and maybe love isn't real but they sure as shit are. But Adora doesn't say any of that. Because to her, none of it is true.

"Yeah," Catra says. "Right"

But as she stares back out into the dark, she thinks that it hears her secrets. It would be a comfort, at least, if one thing in the world but herself knew that she loved Adora, loved her and loved her and would never say the words out loud.

___

Adora says her name, but Catra's already disappeared into the smoking wreckage of Thaymor.

She claws her way back to an airship half-blind, barking some order or another to a pilot to move, and fast.

"But we haven't finished—"

"Did you hear me?" Catra shouts into his visor. "I said *move!*"

The pedal is on the floor before he's even finished calling her 'force captain.'

Catra sinks to the ground, landing with a heavy *thump*. Outside, the woods blur into a smear of color and shadow as they speed away from Adora, from whatever shiny-haired *thing* she became and those shiny new friends she found to replace her. Catra always knew she was replaceable, always knew she was second best, but to see it play out before her very eyes—that was too fucking much.

She squeezes her eyes shut until stars burst across her vision, as if that could possibly blot out her last glimpse of Adora: crumpled and crestfallen, clutching that ridiculous sword; that useless hunk of metal that had torn Catra's life to shreds. If Catra could destroy the thing only by plunging it into her own heart, she'd do it in a second.

She can hardly bring herself to think about what Shadow Weaver's going to do to her when she returns empty handed. All she can think of is Adora, her hand on Catra's wrist, her eyes bright with fear, asking her to drop everything and run back to her side, just like always. The most pathetic part of Catra almost wishes she had done it, just to stay by Adora's side. But she's a survivor, and a survivor needs to be able to rough it alone. No friends, no allies. No princesses.

So what if she never sees Adora again? She doesn't need her. She's *force captain* now. That makes her more important than anyone else in their squadron, and *certainly* more important than

Adora, who will probably get herself killed in the next week or so. Who knows? Maybe in time, she'll be standing where Shadow Weaver stands, at Hordak's right-hand side. (Second best again, again, again.) Try as she might, the thought doesn't bring her any real pleasure.

She hates Adora. She hates Shadow Weaver and the Fright Zone and she hates herself for not dragging Adora back to the Horde the moment she fell off that airship. She can't kid herself; she doesn't want to run the Horde. But if it means destroying Adora, and with it the soft, mewling part of her heart that always aches for her, so be it. She'd burn down the world to stop loving her.

So the airship speeds off into the night, and Catra's claws dig so hard into her palms that when she washes her hands that night, the water runs red for as long as it takes for tears to come and finally blur out the world.

———

Adora is safe. They couldn't get to her. She's with Glimmer and Bow, and so far away. Catra might die or disappear or whatever happens to Horde Prime's enemies, but it doesn't matter; Adora isn't here, and she won't come here, because she doesn't want Catra the way Catra wants her and she never did but it just doesn't matter. Adora is safe.

All being must suffer to become pure.

Adora is safe. They've got her. Adora is safe.

All beings must suffer to become pure.

Adora is…She's…

All beings must suffer to become pure.

Adora. Adora. Adora.

All beings must suffer to become pure.

"Hello, Adora."

——

"Hey, Catra."

Catra groans in their bed. Adora's voice is low and playful, and Catra's feeling anything but. "Why are you awake so early?"

"Because it's the afternoon."

Catra only groans louder. “Oh, what the fuck?”

”You didn’t really think Glimmer would let the party stop before dawn, did you?”

”No.” Slowly, Catra props herself up on her hands; the light of Bright Moon throws itself through their bedroom window, landing on Adora looking as beautiful as Catra feels sick with her hair down and her sleep shirt rumpled and her smile smug and soft. “I just assumed weddings were a little calmer than that.”

”Maybe some of them. But not this one.”

”Yeah, I gathered that.” Catra presses a heel to her pounding head. “God, can you use that sword to cure a hangover?”

”I don’t think so, but I brought the next best thing.” She gestures to a plate of toast—slightly burnt, with barley butter spread overtop. It almost tastes like the gray bars, and she knows it’s Cara’s favorite.

”Oh, *fuck* yeah,” Catra says, and devours it in bed while Adora recounts last night’s exploits. Apparently it involved a lot of dancing and magic light shows and princesses playing spin the bottle with other princesses.

“Who’d have thought Perfuma would be so into Mermista?” Catra asks through a stuffed mouth.

”Most people with eyes.”

”Oh, shut up. Sorry I don’t spend all my time watching your friends.”

Adora softens. “They’re your friends, too, you know.”

Catra takes a moment to look around. She does that sometimes, these days. She takes in the soft bedding, the high windows to let in the starlight and the sunrise, the pictures framed on the walls of dozens of smiling faces. She looks at Adora—all grown up, with broad shoulders and slight laugh lines and a cowlick in her hair that she wears down, now, because the fighting is done and over with. It reminds her that fear is on the back burner, now. That she doesn’t have to be afraid. That even when Catra wanted to die, Adora fought for her, and thank everyone above that she won.

”Yeah,” Catra says eventually. “I know.”

Adora keeps up the idle chatter, about who wore what and what ice sculpture Frosta passed out on, and Catra listens with every molecule in her not because she cares all that much, but because she’s so, so happy that this is what they can talk about now. There is no more war, no more Horde, nothing to drive a wedge between them like the world used to try to do.

There were days—many of them—when Catra thought that it didn't matter how much she loved Adora, because Adora would never love her back. Turned out she was wrong. And she's never been so glad for it. Because it means that she's here, now, sitting in the sunlight in a bed she shares with Adora, and the world is still turning while the two of them finally rest.

Eventually Adora coaxes Catra out to the common area, where Glimmer and Bow are already draped over the couches with a few of their other friends, all looking entirely to healthy for what happened the night before. All except for Bow, that is, who makes sure to make a jab about princesses and their healing powers in Catra's ear when no one is looking. Adora hears, of course, and she only smiles.

The day passes slowly, in softness, in safety, in love. And when Catra tumbles back into bed that night, taking Adora down with her, she can't believe she ever thought it would end any other way. It was a beautiful wedding, Adora whispers against Catra's lips, in the starlight, in the bedsheets. Maybe, maybe, she says. Maybe we could have something like that, too. One day, she says.

And finally, Catra can believe it. Yes, she says, one day, one day, one day.

Because the future will not be ripped away from them, now. Because Catra loves Adora, and Adora loves her, and they're both damn sure of it, and nothing else in the whole stupid world matters.

Besides, they already saved the world. It can handle itself for a while. And in the meantime, Catra and Adora can want each other and keep wanting and finally, finally, finally just have.

End Notes

My melatonin is kicking in pls comment

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!